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ESSAYS
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RUTH WILSON
GILMORE

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Race and Globalization

Theorizing Racism

While there is no legitimate biological basis for dividing the world into racial groupings, *race* is so fundamental a sociopolitical category that it is impossible to think about any aspect of globalization without focusing on the “fatal coupling of power and difference” signified by *racism*.¹ Racism is the state-sanctioned and/or extralegal production and exploitation of group-differentiated vulnerabilities to premature death, in distinct yet densely interconnected political geographies. Wherever in the world the reader encounters this essay, she will have some knowledge of racism’s everyday and extraordinary violences; she will also be sensible of the widening circulation of cultural, aesthetic, and oppositional practices that subjectively mark the difference race makes. For the purposes of this essay, political economy is primary, because so much of globalization concerns material changes in ordinary people’s capacities to make their way in the world. Therefore, by emphasizing racism, the next few pages examine how race is a modality through which political-economic globalization is lived.² A case study of the United States demonstrates how the conjuncture of globalization, legitimate-state limits, and white supremacy reorganizes and contains power through criminalization and imprisonment. These significant political practices, while devised and tested behind the sturdy curtain of racism, have broad national and global articulations—connections

not impeded by racialized boundaries.³ The purpose of focusing on the United States in this essay is not to study an “average” much less “original” racism, but rather to consider how fatal couplings of power and difference in one place develop and change. Then we will consider how they connect with, are amplified by, and materially affect, modalities of globalization elsewhere.

Why should race so vex the planet? Variations in humankind can be regarded in many ways, as contemporary genetics demonstrates.⁴ However, the coupling of European colonialism’s economic imperatives—expansion, exploitation, inequality—with European modernity’s cultural emphasis on the visible⁵ produced a powerful political belief that underlies racialization. The belief can be summed up this way: What counts as difference to the eye transparently embodies explanation for other kinds of differences, and exceptions to such embodied explanation reinforce rather than undermine dominant epistemologies of inequality.⁶ Geographers from Linnaeus forward have figured centrally in the production of race as an object to be known, in part because historically one of the discipline’s motive forces has been to describe the visible world.⁷

To describe is also to produce. While any number of “first contact” texts show that in fact “all cultures are contact cultures,”⁸ the powerful concept of a hierarchy of fixed differences displaced both elite and common knowledges of an alternatively globalized world.⁹ For example, in the mid-fifteenth century, Azurara, court historian to Henry the Navigator (intellectual and financial author of Europe’s African slave trade), noted how many in the first group of human cargo corralled at Lisbon strongly resembled then-contemporary Portuguese; indeed, the captives’ sole shared feature was their grievously wept desire to go home.¹⁰

The triumph of hierarchy required coercive and persuasive forces to coalesce in the service of domination.¹¹ While European militarization constituted the key force that produced and maintained fatally organized couplings of power and difference, Catholic and Protestant missionaries explained and reinforced hierarchical human organization in terms of God-given ineffable processes and eternally guaranteed outcomes.¹² National academies—precursors to today’s

colleges and universities—codified the social world in stringently insulated disciplines which further obscured the world's interconnections.¹³

In the long, murderous twentieth century, geographers used three main frameworks to study race: environmental determinism,¹⁴ areal differentiation,¹⁵ and social construction.¹⁶ The variety of frameworks, and the fact of transition from one to another, demonstrates both how geography has been deeply implicated in the development of inequality and how critical disciplinary reconstruction at times seeks to identify and remedy the social effects of intellectual wrongs. In other words, frameworks—or “paradigms”¹⁷—are not structures that emerge with spontaneous accuracy in the context of knowledge production. Rather, they are politically and socially as well as empirically contingent and contested explanations for how things work that, once widely adopted, are difficult to disinherit.

Geographers who embraced environmental determinism sought to explain domination and subordination—power and difference in terms of groups' relative life-chances—by reference to the allegedly formative climates and landscapes of conqueror and conquered. The framework assumed, and therefore persistently demonstrated, that inequality is a product of natural rather than sociopolitical capacities; while culture might revise, it can never fully correct.¹⁸ In this view inequality is irremediable, and thus should be exploited or erased. Examples of exploitation and erasure include US and South African apartheid, the Third Reich's “Final Solution,” scorched-earth wars against Central American indigenous groupings, and other cleansing schemes.

As if in recognition of environmental determinism's horrifying consequences, the second framework, areal differentiation, seized the seemingly unbiased tools of the quantitative revolution to map distributions of difference across landscapes. The areal approach featured a mild curiosity toward the political-economic origins of inequalities, by suggesting causes for certain kinds of spatial mismatches or overlays. But in the end, taking race as a given, and development as the proper project for social change, the approach described territorialized objects (people and places as if they were

things) rather than socio-spatial processes (how people and places came to be organized as they are).¹⁹

Inquiry into processes shapes a prevalent critical geographical framework. Neither voluntaristic nor idealistic, social construction refuses to naturalize race, even while recognizing its socio-spatial and ideological materiality. At its relational best, the social construction approach considers how racialization is based in the (until recently) under-analyzed production of both masculinity and whiteness (foundation and byproduct of global European hegemony), and how, therefore, race and space are mutually constituted.²⁰ How do spatially specific relations of power and difference—legal, political, cultural—racialize bodies, groupings, activities, and places? Why are such relations reproducible? For example, how is it that globally dynamic interactions, organized according to liberal theories of individual sovereignty, protection, grievance, and remedy (“human rights”), reconfigure but do not dismantle planetary white male supremacy—as measured by multinational corporate ownership, effective control over finance capital, and national military killing capacity?

While the three approaches span a wide political spectrum, from racist eugenics to anti-racist multiculturalism and beyond, all, at least implicitly, share two assumptions: (1) societies are structured in dominance within and across scales; and (2) race is in some way determinate of socio-spatial location.²¹ A way to understand the first point is to think about all the components—or institutions—of a society at any scale, and then ask about differences of power within and between them. Are corporations stronger than labor unions? Do poor families rank equally with wealthy ones? Does education receive the same kind of financial and political support, or command the same attention to demands, as police or the military? Do small food producers enjoy the same protections and opportunities as agribusinesses? Are industrial pollutants and other toxic wastes spread evenly across the landscape? Do those who produce toxins pay to contain them? Are people tried in courts by juries of their peers? Having thought about these kinds of institutional relationships, turn to the second assumption: According to the society’s official or common-sense classifications, how does race

figure in and between the institutions?²² While this thought-experiment is only a crude cross-section, the conclusions strongly suggest that—as all the twentieth-century frameworks agree—race, while slippery, is also structural.

But what structures does race make? Let us turn the question inside out and ask how fatal couplings of power and difference might be globally represented. Any map of modernity's fundamental features—growth, industrialization, articulation, urbanization, and inequality—as measured by wealth, will also map historical-geographical racisms. Such a map is the product of rounds and rounds of globalization, five centuries' movement of people, commodities, and people as commodities, along with ideologies and political forms, forever commingled by terror, syncretism, truce, and sometimes love. The cumulative effects of worldwide colonialism, transatlantic slavery, Western hemisphere genocide, and postcolonial imperialism—plus ongoing opposition to these effects—appear today, on any adequate planetary map of the twenty-first century, as power-difference topographies (for example, North, South) unified by the ineluctable fatalities attending asymmetrical wealth transfers.

So far, the discussion is pitched at a general level of abstraction. Our map of contemporary globalization circulation models (GCMs) is built on the historical geographies of past GCMs and signifies underlying struggles that indicate global warming of a peculiar kind. Indubitably anthropogenic, the racialized heat of political-economic antagonisms sheds light on the forms of organized abandonment that constitute the other side of globalism's uneven development coin:²³ structural adjustment, environmental degradation, privatization, genetic modification, land expropriation, forced sterilization, human organ theft, neocolonialism, involuntary and superexploited labor.

At the same time, the realities of racism are not the same everywhere and represent different practices at different geographical scales—which are connected (or “articulated”) in many ways.²⁴ Within and across scales—respectively configuring nation-states, production regions, labor markets, communities, households,

and bodies²⁵—anti-racist activism encounters supple enactments and renewals of racialization through law, policy, and legal and illegal practices performed by state and non-state actors. The key point is this: at any scale, racism is not a lagging indicator, an anachronistic drag on an otherwise achievable social equality guaranteed by the impersonal freedom of expanding markets. History is not a long march from premodern racism to postmodern pluralism.²⁶ Rather, racism's changing same does triple duty: claims of *natural* or *cultural* incommensurabilities secure conditions for reproducing *economic* inequalities, which then validate theories of extra-economic hierarchical difference. In other words, racism functions as a limiting force that pushes disproportionate costs of participating in an increasingly monetized and profit-driven world onto those who, due to the frictions of *political* distance, cannot reach the variable levers of power that might relieve them of those costs.²⁷

What is the character of such friction? Why is the cost of mobility so prohibitive for some, especially in the current period that is colloquially characterized by increased (some say *hyper-*) mobilities? Race and racism are historical and specific, cumulative and territorially distinct—although distinct does not mean either isolated or unique. But while already-existing *material inequality* shapes political landscapes, the contested grounds are also *ideological*, because how we understand and make sense of the world and ourselves in it shapes how we do what we do.²⁸ In any society, those who dominate produce *normative* primary definitions of human worth through academic study, laws, and the applied activities of medical and other “experts,” as well as through schooling, news, entertainment, and other means of mass education.²⁹ Those who are dominated produce counterdefinitions which, except in extraordinary moments of crisis, are structurally secondary to primary definitions. While such counterdefinitions might constitute “local” common sense, their representation in the wider ideological field is as sporadically amplified *responses* to regional norms—rather than as the fundamental terms of debate.³⁰ On all fronts, then, racism always means struggle. Whether radically revolutionary or minimally reformist, anti-racism is fought from many different kinds of

positions, rather than between two teams faced off on a flat, featureless plain. Indeed, organized and unorganized anti-racist struggle is a feature of everyday life, and the development and reproduction of collective oppositional capacities bear opportunity costs which, in a peculiar limit to that fiscal metaphor, are hard to transfer *collectively* to other purposes within “already partitioned” political geographies.³¹ Therefore, if, as many activist-theorists note, coercion is expensive,³² anti-coercion cannot be cheap.

The deepening divide between the hyper-mobile and the friction-fixed produces something that would not surprise Albert Einstein: depending on their socio-spatial location in the global political economy, certain people are likely to experience “time-space compression”³³ as time-space *expansion*. We shall now turn to a case study of the United States to see how intensified criminalization and imprisonment constitute such an expansion and then conclude by considering some global effects of US anti-Black racism. The reader must bear in mind that US racism is not the model but rather the case and that US racism is not singularly anti-Black; the larger point, then, is to consider both how racism is produced through, and informs the territorial, legal, social, and philosophical organization of a place, and also how racism fatally articulates with other power-difference couplings such that its effects can be amplified beyond a place even if its structures remain particular and local.

Prison and Globalization

Ever since Richard M. Nixon’s 1968 campaign for US president on a “law and order” platform, the United States has been home to a pulsing moral panic over crime. Between 1980 and 2000 the “law and order” putsch swelled prisons and jails with 1.68 million people, so that today [2002] 2,000,000 women, men, boys, and girls live in cages.³⁴ The US rate of imprisonment is the highest in the world.³⁵ African Americans and Latinos comprise two-thirds of the prison population; 7 percent are women of all races. Almost half the

prisoners had steady employment before they were arrested, while upwards of 80 percent were at some time represented by state-appointed lawyers for the indigent: in short, as a class, convicts are the working or workless poor. Why did “the law” enmesh so many people so quickly, but delay casting its dragnet for a decade after Nixon’s successful bid for the presidency?

The 1938–68 World War II and Cold War military buildup produced a territorial redistribution of wealth from the urban industrialized northeast and north central to the agricultural and resource dominated south and coastal west.³⁶ While one urban-rural wealth gap was narrowed by state-funded military development, the equalization of wealth between regions masked deepening inequalities *within* regions as measured in both racial and urban-rural terms.³⁷

Military Keynesianism characterized the US version of a *welfare* state: the enormous outlays and consequent multipliers for inventing, producing, and staffing *warfare* capacities underwrote modest social protections against calamity, alongside opportunities for advancement. Prior to the military buildup, the New Deal United States developed social welfare capacities, the design of which were objects of fierce interregional struggle.³⁸ In concert with the successful political struggle by the Union’s most rigorously codified *and* terrorist white supremacist regimes³⁹ to make the south and west principal sites for military agglomeration, the federal government also expanded to the national scale—via the structure of welfare programs—particular racial and gender inequalities.⁴⁰ As a result, under the New Deal white people fared better than people of color; women had to apply individually for what men received as entitlements; and urban industrial workers secured limited labor rights denied agricultural and household workers.⁴¹

The welfare-warfare state⁴² (another way to think of “military Keynesianism”) was first and foremost a safety net for the capital class as a whole⁴³ in all major areas: collective investment, labor division and control, comparative regional and sectoral advantage, national consumer market integration, and global reach. Up until 1967–68 the capital class paid high taxes for such extensive

insurance.⁴⁴ But in the mid-1960s the rate of profit, which had climbed for nearly thirty years, began to drop off. Large corporations and banks, anxious about the flattening profit curve, began to agitate forcefully and successfully to reduce their taxes. Capital's tax revolts, fought out in federal and state legislatures and at the Federal Reserve Bank, provoked the decline of military Keynesianism.⁴⁵ The primary definers of the system's demise laid responsibility at the door of unruly people of color, rather than in the halls of capital—where overdevelopment of productive capacity weighed against future earnings⁴⁶ and therefore demanded a new relation with labor mediated by the state.

The 1968 law-and-order campaign was part of a successful “southern strategy” aimed at bringing white-supremacist Democrats from *anywhere* into the Republican fold.⁴⁷ Mid-1960s radical activism—both spontaneous and organized—had successfully produced widespread disorder throughout society. The ascendant right used the fact of disorder to persuade voters that the incumbents failed to govern. The claim accurately described objective conditions. But in order to exploit the evidence for political gain, the right had to interpret the turmoil as something they could contain, if elected, using already-existing, unexceptionable capacities: the power to defend the nation against enemies foreign and domestic. And so the *contemporary* US crime problem was born, in the context of solidifying the political incorporation of the militarized south and west into a broadening anti-New Deal conservatism. The disorder that became “crime” had particular urban and racial qualities, and the collective characteristics of activists—whose relative visibility as enemies inversely reflected their structural powerlessness—defined the face of the individual criminal. To deepen its claims, the right assigned the welfare-warfare state's *social* project institutional responsibility for the anxiety and upheaval of the period.

The postwar liberation movement focused in part on extending eligibility to those who had been deliberately excluded from New Deal legislation. While some factions of the civil rights movement worked to bring about simple inclusion, radical African, Latino, Asian, and Native American groupings fought the many ways the state at all

scales organized poor people's perpetual dispossession.⁴⁸ Radical white activists both aligned with people of color and launched autonomous attacks against symbols and strongholds of US capitalism and Euro-American racism and imperialism.

Indeed, growing opposition to the US war in Southeast Asia helped forge an international community of resistance. At the same time, activism against colonialism and apartheid on a world scale found in Black Power a compelling renewal of linkages between "First" and "Third World" Pan-African and other liberation struggles.⁴⁹ Meanwhile, students and workers built and defended barricades from Mexico City to Paris: no sooner had smoke cleared in one place than fires of revolt flared up in another. The more that militant anti-capitalism and international solidarity became everyday features of US *anti-racist activism*, the more vehemently the state and its avatars responded by "individualizing disorder"⁵⁰ into singular instances of criminality—which could then be solved via arrest or state-sanctioned killings.

Both institutional and individualized condemnation were essential because the deadly anti-racist struggle had been nationally televised. Television affected the outlook of ordinary US white people who had to be persuaded that welfare did not help them (it did) and that justice should be measured by punishing individuals rather than via social reconstruction.⁵¹ Thus, the political will for *militarism* remained intact, but the will for *equity* (another way to think about welfare), however weak it had been, yielded to pressure for privatizing or eliminating public—or social—goods and services. In other words, the basic structure of the postwar US racial state⁵² has shifted, from welfare-warfare to workfare-warfare, and that shift is the product of, and is producing, a new political as well as economic geography.

The expansion of prison coincides with this fundamental shift and constitutes a geographical solution to socioeconomic problems, politically organized by the state which is, itself, in the process of radical restructuring. This view brings the complexities and contradictions of globalization to the fore, by showing how already-existing social, political, and economic relations constitute the

conditions of possibility (but not inevitability) for ways to solve major problems. In the present case, “major problems” appear, materially and ideologically, as surpluses of finance capital, land, labor, and state capacity that have accumulated from a series of overlapping and interlocking crises stretching across three decades.

In the wake of capital’s tax revolt, and the state’s first movements toward restructuring both capital-labor and international economic relations, the United States slipped into the long mid-1970s recession. Inflation consequent to abandonment of the gold standard⁵³ and rising energy costs sent prices skyward, while at the same time steep unemployment deepened the effects of high inflation for workers and their families. Big corporations eliminated jobs and factories in high-wage heavy industries (for example, auto, steel, rubber), decimating entire regions of the country and emptying cities of wealth and people. Even higher unemployment plagued farmworkers and timber, fishing, mining, and other rural workers. Landowners’ revenues did not keep up with the cost of money because of changing production processes and product markets, as well as seemingly “natural” disasters. Defaults displaced both large and smaller farmers and other kinds of rural producers from their devalued lands, with the effect that land and rural industry ownership sped up the century-long tendency to concentrate.⁵⁴

Urban dwellers left cities, looking for new jobs, cheaper housing,⁵⁵ or whiter communities, while new suburban residential and industrial districts developed as center-cities crumbled. Those left behind were stuck in space, their mobility hampered by the frictions of diminished political and economic power. As specific labor markets collapsed, entire cohorts of modestly educated men and women—particularly people of color, but also poor white people—lost employment and saw household income drop.⁵⁶ Meanwhile, international migrants arrived in the United States, pushed and pulled across borders by the same forces producing the US cataclysm.

The state’s ability to intervene in these displacements was severely constrained by its waning legitimacy to use existing welfare capacities to mitigate crises. However, what withered was not the

abstract geopolitical institution called “the state,” but rather the short-lived *welfare* partner to the ongoing *warfare* state.⁵⁷ Unabsorbed accumulations from the 1973–77 recession lay the groundwork for additional surpluses idled in the 1981–84 recession, and again in 1990–94, as the furious integration of some worlds produced the terrifying disintegration of others.

Prison Expansion

Many map the new geography according to the gross capital movements we call “globalization.” This chapter proposes a different cartographic effort, which is to map the political geography of the contemporary United States by positing at the center the site where state-building is least contested, yet most class based and racialized: the prison. A prison-centered map shows dynamic connections among (1) criminalization; (2) imprisonment; (3) wealth transfer between poor communities; (4) disfranchisement; and (5) migration of state and non-state practices, policies, and capitalist ventures that all depend on carcerality as a basic state-building project. These are all forms of structural adjustment and have interregional, national, and international consequences. In other words, if economics lies at the base of the prison system, its growth is a function of politics, not mechanics.

The political geography of criminal law in the United States is a mosaic of state statutes overlaid by juridically distinct federal law. Although no single lawmaking body determines crimes and their consequences, there are trends that more than 52 legislative bodies have followed and led each other along over the past two decades. The trends center on (1) making previously noncriminal behavior criminal, (2) increasing sentences for old and new crimes, and (3) refiguring minor offenses as major ones. More than 70 percent of new convicts in 1999 were sentenced for nonviolent crimes, with drug convictions in the plurality—30 percent of new state prisoners and 60 percent of all federal prisoners.⁵⁸ Even what counts as

“violence” has broadened over this period.⁵⁹ The summary effect of these trends has been a general convergence toward ineluctable and long prison terms.

The weight of new and harsher laws falls on poor people in general and especially people of color—who are disproportionately poor. Indigenous people, and people of African descent (citizens and immigrants), are the most criminalized groups. Their rate of incarceration climbed steeply over the past twenty years, while economic opportunity for modestly educated people fell drastically and state programs for income guarantees and job creation withered under both Republican and Democratic administrations.⁶⁰ Citizen and immigrant Latinos in collapsing primary or insecure secondary labor markets have experienced intensified incarceration; and there has been a steady increase in citizen and immigrant Asian and Pacific Islanders in prison and jail.⁶¹ Finally, at the same time that revisions to federal law have curtailed constitutional protections for noncitizens accused of crimes and for all persons convicted of crimes, immigration law has adopted criminalization as a weapon to control cross-border movement and to disrupt settlement of working people who are non-elite long-distance migrants.⁶²

Does the lawmaking and prison building fury mean there’s more crime? Although data are difficult to compare because of changes in categories, the best estimate for crime as a driving force of prison expansion shows it to account for little more than 10 percent of the increase. Rather, it is a greater propensity to lock people up, as opposed to people’s greater propensity to do old or new illegal things, that accounts for about 90 percent of US prison and jail growth since 1980. People who are arrested are more likely now than twenty years ago to be detained pending trial; and those convicted are more likely to be sentenced to prison or jail and for longer terms than earlier cohorts.⁶³

A counterintuitive proposition might also help further understanding of why there are so many US residents in prison. The lockup punishment imperative must be positively correlated with lockup space. Legislative bodies can make any number of laws requiring prison terms, and they can, in theory, drastically overcrowd

prisons and then build new prisons to correct for noncompliance with constitutional, if not international,⁶⁴ custody standards. However, if one scrutinizes the temporality of prison growth in California, the largest US state, one sees that lawmaking expanding criminalization followed, rather than led, the historically unprecedented building boom the state embarked on in the early 1980s. And the inception of the building boom followed, rather than led, significant, well-reported, reductions in crime.⁶⁵ A similar pattern holds true for the other leading prison state, Texas.⁶⁶ The new structures are built on surplus land that is no longer a factor in productive activity. Virtually all new prisons have been sited in rural areas, where dominant monopoly or oligopoly capitals have either closed down or, through centralization and/or mechanization, reorganized their participation in the economy.

In search of new prison sites, state prison agencies and private prison entrepreneurs (to whom we shall return) present lockup facilities as local economic development drivers. Recent quantitative and qualitative research in the United States⁶⁷ demonstrates that prisons do not produce the promised outcomes for a number of reasons. New prison employees do not live in amenities-starved towns where prisons go, while 60–95 percent of new prison jobs go to outsiders. Prisons have no industrial agglomeration effects. The preponderance of local institutional purchases is for utilities, which are usually extra-locally owned. Locally owned retail and service establishments such as restaurants are displaced by multinational chains, which drain already scant profits from the locality.

When a prison site is authorized, land values increase amid the euphoria of expected growth, but after construction values drop again. Anticipatory development—particularly new and rehabilitated housing—fails, leaving homeowners (especially the elderly) with their sole asset effectively devalued due to increased vacancies. Renters bear higher fixed costs because of hikes during the short-lived construction boom. As a result, prisons can actually intensify local economic bifurcation.

At the same time, prisons produce a local economy dependent on constant statehouse politicking to maintain inflows of cash. In one

mayor's words: "Beds. We're always lobbying for more beds." "More beds" means more prisoners.⁶⁸ Most prisoners come from urban areas, where the combination of aggressive law-enforcement practices⁶⁹ and greater structural strains⁷⁰ produces higher arrest and conviction rates than in rural areas⁷¹; suburbia is following urban trends.⁷²

The movement of prisoners is, in effect, a wealth transfer between poor communities, and there isn't enough wealth in the sending community to create real economic growth in the receiving community.⁷³ Taxes and other benefits that are spatially allocated on a per capita basis count prisoners where they are held, not where they are from.⁷⁴ When prisoners' families make long trips to visit, they spend scarce but relatively elastic funds in motels and eating establishments. Towns disappointed by the lack of prison-induced real growth console themselves with these meager rewards, although modest tax subventions and families' expenditures hardly constitute an income tide to lift ships. Prisons also provide localities with free prisoner labor for public works and beautification, which can displace local low-wage workers.

Global Implications

Throughout the globalizing world, states at all scales are working to renovate their ability to be powerful actors in rapidly changing landscapes of accumulation. Already-existing capacities, antagonisms, and agreements are the raw materials of political renovation; embedded in renovation work, then, is the possibility (although by no means *certainly*) that already-existing frictions of distance may be intensified. The rise of prisons in the United States is a potentially prime factor in future "globalization circulation models" because prison-building is state-building at its least contested, and the United States is a prime exporter of ideologies and systems. The transfer of social control methods, in times of political-economic crisis, is not new. A century ago, Jim Crow,

apartheid, racist science, eugenics, and other precursors to twentieth century hypersegregation, exclusion, and genocide took ideological and material form and globalized in conjunction with technology transfers and dreams of democracy.⁷⁵

In the current period the legitimizing growth of state social control apparatuses productively connects with the needs of those who struggle to gain or keep state power. Such political actors (whether parties, corporations, industrial sectors, or other kinds of interest groups makes no difference) are vulnerable to the arguments of private entrepreneurs and public technocrats about how states *should* function in the evolving global arena, when the norm has become neoliberal minimalism. Increased coercive control within jurisdictions is, as we have seen in the US context, one way to manage the effects of organized abandonment. At the same time, the struggle for *international* sovereignty in the context of “postcolonial” globalization can, and often does, feature a rush to institutional conformity—which today includes expanded criminalization, policing, and prisons. As a result, new or renovated state structures are often grounded in the exact same fatal power-difference couplings (for example, racism, sexism, homophobia) that radical anti-colonial activists fought to expunge from the social order.⁷⁶

In other words, structural adjustment—most ordinarily associated with shifts in how states intervene in the costs of everyday-life basic-goods subsidies, wage rules, and other benefits—flags not only what states stop doing, but also what states do instead.⁷⁷ Policing and lawmaking are internationally articulated, via professional and governmental associations,⁷⁸ and the pressures of international finance capitalists (whether commercial or not-for-profit) seeking to secure predictable returns on investments. In short, while not all countries in the world rush to emulate the United States, the very kinds of state-based contingencies and opportunities that help explain US prison expansion operate elsewhere.⁷⁹

US prison expansion has other broad effects. While most US prisons and jails are publicly owned and operated, the trend toward public service privatization means firms work hard to turn the

deprivation of freedom for 2,000,000 into profit-making opportunities for shareholders. Success rates differ across jurisdictions, but privatized market share, currently about 6 percent, grew 25–35 percent each year during the 1990s.⁸⁰ The largest firms doing this work also promote privatization in such disparate places as the United Kingdom, South Africa, and Australia.⁸¹

Public and private entities package and market prison design, construction, and fund-development; they also advocate particular kinds of prison-space organization and prisoner management techniques. The “security housing unit” (SHU), a hyper-isolation “control unit” cell condemned by international human rights organizations, is widely used in the United States. The United States imported the SHU from the former West Germany, which developed it as a death penalty surrogate to destroy the political will and physical bodies of radical activists. The United States has both the death penalty and the SHU and promotes control units abroad.⁸² At the end of 2000 more than 10,000 prisoners throughout Turkey participated in a hunger strike to protest spatial reconfiguration from dormitories to cell-based “American”-style prison, with a particular focus on the punitive SHU.⁸³

Exported structures and relationships can take the form of indirect as well as deliberately patterned effects. In addition to the transfer of wealth between poor places, prison produces the political transfer of electoral power through formal disfranchisement of felons. While elections and politics are not identical, the power to vote has been central to struggles for self-determination for people kept from the polls by the frictions of terror and law throughout the world. In the United States, Black people fought an entire century (1865–1965) for the vote. As of 1998, there were nearly 4 million felony-disfranchised adults in the country, of whom 1.37 million are of African descent.⁸⁴ The voter effect of criminalization returns the United States to the era when white supremacist statutes barred millions from decision-making processes; today, lockout is achieved through lockup.

The 2000 US presidential election, strangely decided by the Supreme Court rather than voters, was indirectly determined by massive disfranchisement. George W. Bush Jr. won Florida, and

therefore the White House and the most powerful job on the planet, by fewer than 500 votes. Yet 204,600 Black Floridians were legally barred from voting; additionally, many others of all races who tried to vote could not because their names appeared on felon lists. Had felons not been disfranchised, candidate Bush would have lost; however, candidate Albert Gore's party shares equal responsibility with Bush's for creating widespread disfranchisement and could not protest on that front. Thus, the structural effects of racism significantly shape the electoral sphere with ineluctably global consequences for financial (G8), industrial (WTO and GATT), environmental (Kyoto), and warfare (NATO; Star Wars) policies.

Conclusion

As exercised through criminal laws that target certain kinds of people in places disorganized by globalization's adjustments, racism is structural—not individual or incidental. The sturdy curtain of US racism enables and veils the complex economic, political, and social processes of prison expansion. Through prison expansion and prison export, both US and non-US racist practices can become determining forces in places nominally “free” of white supremacy. Indeed, as with the twentieth, the problem of the twenty-first century is freedom; and racialized lines continue powerfully, although not exclusively, to define freedom's contours and limits.

Fatal Couplings of Power and Difference: Notes on Racism and Geography

Who Am I?

I locate my work within the broad areas of social theory, political economy, and labor and social movements. In my research and writing, I investigate, largely in the US context, overdeterminations of race, gender, class, and power. The geographical impulses shaping my analyses are deliberately counterintuitive. What I wish to do is disarticulate common-sense couplings of sites and struggles and disrupt assumptions such as the idea that politics happens in the milieu of the state or that value comes from wage-controlled workplaces. At the same time, I am not throwing out the historical-materialist baby with the well-used bathwaters of three decades of Marxist geography.

My goal is to emulate the work of engaged scholars who try to find in the organizational foundations of social-movement building something other than perpetual recapitulation of ongoing place-based struggles that are displaced but never resolved.¹ By “place” I mean, following Neil Smith’s typology of scale, the *range of kinds of places*— as intimate as the body and as abstract, yet distinctive, as a productive region or a nation-state.²

For the past decade [this essay was originally published in 2002], I have focused my scholarly energy on several projects that developed from ongoing political activism. I am finishing a book

Americans and the Christian Right: The Gendered Politics of Unlikely Alliances, Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2008).

19 “Terror Austerity Race Gender Excess Theater,” in this volume, 154–175; Gilmore, “‘You Have Dislodged a Boulder,’” in this volume, 355–409; Wendy Brown, *States of Injury*, Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1994.

20 George Lakoff, *Moral Politics: How Liberals and Conservatives Think*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1996.

21 For exemplary critiques, see the following: on paradigm shifts, see Thomas Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1962; on race and categories, see Denise Ferreira da Silva, *Race and Nation in the Mapping of Modern Global Space*, Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2005; on radical traditions, see Cedric J. Robinson, *Black Marxism and the Making of the Black Radical Tradition*, London: Zed Books, 1982; on theory, see Barbara Christian, “The Race for Theory,” *Cultural Critique* 6 (1987): 51–63; and on topography, see Cindi Katz, “On the Grounds of Globalization: A Topography for Feminist Political Engagement,” *Signs* 26 (2001): 1213–1234.

22 Neil Smith, “Contours of Spatialized Politics: Homeless Vehicles and the Production of Geographical Scale,” *Social Text* 33 (1993): 55–81.

23 See, for example, Laura Pulido, “Rethinking Environmental Racism: White Privilege and Urban Development in Southern California,” *Annals of the Association of American Geographers* 90 (2000): 12–40.

24 Barad, “Getting Real.”

25 Gramsci, *Selections from the Prison Notebooks*.

26 Wallerstein, *Unthinking Social Science*.

5. Race and Globalization

1 Stuart Hall, “Old and New Identities, Old and New Ethnicities,” in A. D. King (ed.), *Culture, Globalization and the World-System*, London: Macmillan, 1992. Some theorists prefer the plural—racisms—to underscore how there is not a single universal practice. I use the singular because racism, like other forms of violence, tends to produce the same outcomes regardless of technique: premature death and other life-limiting inequalities.

2 Stuart Hall, “Race, Articulation, and Societies Structured in Dominance,” in *Sociological Theories: Race and Colonialism*, Paris: UNESCO, 1980, 305–340.

3 Ruth Wilson Gilmore, “Globalization and US Prison Growth: From Military Keynesianism to Post-Keynesian Militarism,” in this volume, 199–223; Ruth Wilson Gilmore, “From Military Keynesianism to Post-Keynesian Militarism: Finance Capital, Land, Labor, and Opposition in the Rising U.S. Prison State,” PhD diss., Rutgers: The State University of New Jersey, 1998; Avery F. Gordon, “Globalism

and the Prison Industrial Complex: An Interview with Angela Y. Davis," *Race and Class* 40.2/3 (1988): 145–157.

4 Richard C. Lewontin, Steven Rose, and Leon J. Kamin, *Not in Our Genes*, New York: Pantheon, 1984.

5 John Berger, *About Looking*, New York: Pantheon, 1980.

6 Paul Gilroy, *Against Race: Imagining Political Culture beyond the Color Line*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2000 (published in the UK as: *Between Camps: Nations, Cultures, and the Allure of Race*, London: Allen Lane, 2000).

7 David N. Livingstone, *The Geographical Tradition*, Oxford: Blackwell, 1992.

8 Brackette F. Williams, "Contact Cultures," Panel, Annual Meeting of the Association of American Anthropologists, San Francisco, February 1992.

9 Jim Blaut, *The Colonizer's Model of the World: Geographical Diffusion and Eurocentric History*, New York: Guilford, 1994; Bernard Lewis, *The Muslim Discovery of Europe*, New York: W. W. Norton, 1982; V.Y. Mudimbe, *The Invention of Africa: Gnosis, Philosophy and the Order of Knowledge*, Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1988.

10 Ronald Sanders, *Lost Tribes and Promised Lands*, New York: Harper Perennial, 1978.

11 Edward Said, *Culture and Imperialism*, New York: Knopf, 1993.

12 David Stannard, *American Holocaust*, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1992.

13 Immanuel Wallerstein, *Unthinking Social Science*, Cambridge: Polity Press, 1989; Omer Bartov, *Murder in Our Midst: The Holocaust, Industrial Killing, and Representation*, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1996.

14 See Don Mitchell, *Cultural Geography*, Oxford: Blackwell, 2000.

15 See David Harvey, *Explanation in Geography*, London: Edward Arnold, 1969.

16 For example, Peter Jackson and Jan Penrose (eds.), *Constructions of "Race," Place, and Nation*, Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1993; Audrey Kobayashi and Linda Peake, "Unnatural Discourse: 'Race' and Gender in Geography," *Gender, Place and Culture* 1.2 (1994): 225–43; Ruth Wilson Gilmore, "'You Have Dislodged a Boulder': Mothers and Prisoners in the Post Keynesian California Landscape," in this volume, 355–409; Ruth Wilson Gilmore, "Fatal Couplings of Power and Difference: Notes on Racism and Geography," in this volume, 132–153; Laura Y. Liu, "The Place of Geography in Studies of Geography and Race," *Social and Cultural Geography* 1.2 (2000): 169–82.

17 Thomas Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1996.

18 For example, Ellsworth Huntington, *The Character of Races*, New York: Scribner's, 1924.

19 Gilmore, "Fatal Couplings of Power and Difference."

20 Vron Ware, *Beyond the Pale*, London: Verso, 1992; Laura Pulido, "Rethinking Environmental Racism," *Annals of the AAG* 90.1 (2000): 12–40. The articulations of race and space—as and through multiscalar hierarchies of colonialism, slavery, and other relations of unfreedom—are more evident in some contexts than in others. For some examples of how race becomes both amplified and entrenched, see Center for Contemporary Cultural Studies, *The Empire Strikes Back*, London: Hutchinson, 1982; and Mitchell, *Cultural Geography*.

21 Hall, "Race, Articulation, and Societies Structured in Dominance."

22 Susan Christopherson provides an exemplary chart for doing this exercise on a global scale. Susan Christopherson, "Changing Women's Status in a Global Economy," in R. J. Johnston, Peter J. Taylor, and Michael J. Watts, eds., *Geographies of Global Change: Mapping the World*, 2nd ed., Malden, MA: Blackwell, 2002.

23 Neil Smith, *Uneven Development*.

24 See, for example, Allan Pred, *Even in Sweden: Racisms, Racialized Spaces, and the Popular Geographical Imagination*, Berkeley: University of California Press, 2000.

25 Neil Smith, "Contours of a Spatialized Politics," *Social Text* 33 (1992): 54–81.

26 Peter Linebaugh and Marcus Rediker, *The Many-Headed Hydra: Sailors, Slaves, Commoners, and the Hidden History of the Revolutionary Atlantic*, Boston: Beacon Press, 2000.

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30 Stuart Hall et al., *Policing the Crisis: Mugging, the State, and Law and Order*.

31 Smith, "Contours of a Spatialized Politics," 66.

32 For example, Frantz Fanon, *The Wretched of the Earth*, New York: Grove, 1961.

33 David Harvey, *The Condition of Postmodernity: An Enquiry into the Origins of Cultural Change*, Oxford: Blackwell, 1989.

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35 Jenni Gainsborough and Marc Mauer, *Diminishing Returns: Crime and Incarceration in the 1990s*, Washington, DC: The Sentencing Project, 2000.

36 Gregory Hooks, *Forging the Military-Industrial Complex*, Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1991; Ann Markusen, Peter Hall, Scott Campbell, and Sabina Deitrick, *The Rise of the Gunbelt*, New York: Oxford University Press, 1991.

37 Bruce J. Schulman, *From Cotton Belt to Sunbelt*, Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1994; Gilmore, "From Military Keynesianism to Post-Keynesian Militarism."

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39 Ralph Ginzburg, *100 Years of Lynching*, Baltimore: Black Classic Press, 1988 [1962]; C. McWilliams, *Factories in the Field: The Story of Migratory Farm Labor in California*, Berkeley: University of California Press, 1999 [1939].

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44 Ruth Wilson Gilmore, *Golden Gulag: Prisons, Surplus, Crisis, and Opposition in Globalizing California*, Berkeley: University of California Press, 2007.

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6. Fatal Couplings of Power and Difference: Notes on Racism and Geography